

were the years that the tax-saving investment was the only investment we could afford to make. And there were years in which we could not make the maximum Rs 70,000 investment for the year. And then, even that came down over the next few years because I took a financially risky call.

The early years are tougher for young mothers. I went right back to work after my maternity leave – the family needed the money. But by the time our daughter was a year old, I could see that it really upset her to see me leave for work. I too could not focus fully on work thinking about her missing me. It got to a stage where I decided to quit and look after the baby. We were moving cities with my husband in a new and slightly better-paying job, and I decided to go cold turkey and quit. I still remember that feeling of stepping off a cliff. *BA kiya hai, MA kiya. Lagta hai ye sab yu hi kiya.*

A bachelor's from Shri Ram College of Commerce, master's from Delhi School of Economics and a second master's, in journalism, from the UK – and I'm going full-time mom! Many of my girl-friends were not impressed. Some work-related friends stopped talking to me thinking that my career was over. We went from a two-income home to a one-income home in a high-risk profession called journalism. This was financial disaster, but I was convinced that I wanted to be home for my kid. That meant a few years of skimming hard on costs and comforts. No eating out or shopping or holidays. But gosh, the joy of bringing up a baby! She's now in her twenties, and I look back with so much gratitude at my younger avatar for not letting me have regrets today. Those years are today worth all my net worth and more. They are priceless.

I was on a baby break for about seven years, and in those years I picked up odd writing jobs and editing projects, had signed up for the new emerging qualification called Certified Financial Planner (CFP), joined a training outfit and trained financial sector employees after a short course, and wrote for a US-based internet magazine (*Industry Standard*) during the Y2K boom years for which I got paid a dollar a word. That was the one year when we ate out, bought some decent clothes and took a holiday. And then the magazine shut down!

Anyhow, the short story is that I kept earning bits and pieces even while not formally working. I managed to requalify myself. And I learnt only to spend money after I earned it. I still remember buying my first AC in sweltering Delhi